

MEXICAN TRAIN

A domino game for 2–8 players using a **double-12 set** (91 tiles). All trains radiate from a central double (the **hub**). Each player builds their own personal train; a shared **Mexican Train** is always open for anyone to play on. A match consists of 13 rounds (starting from double-12 down to double-0).

COMPONENTS

- ♦ **Double-12 set:** 91 tiles (pips 0–12 per half)
- ♦ **Hub:** a central station piece (or an empty tile slot) where trains begin
- ♦ **Train markers:** one per player (coins or tokens) to mark an open personal train

Double-9 (55 tiles, 10 rounds) is a common alternative for smaller groups.

SETUP

- 1 Place the **hub** in the centre.
- 2 The starting double for the round (double-12 in round 1, double-11 in round 2, etc.) is placed on the hub. If no player holds it, draw from the boneyard until found.
- 3 Deal tiles to each player:

PLAYERS	TILES PER PLAYER
2–3	16
4	15
5	14
6	12
7–8	10

Remaining tiles form the **boneyard** (face-down draw pile).

STARTING TRAINS

In the first phase, starting with the player left of the dealer and proceeding clockwise, each player lays down as many tiles as they can to start their **personal train** from the hub. The train must begin with a tile whose pip matches the hub double.

If a player cannot start their train, they draw one tile and play it if possible, or place a train marker on their train space.

TURN STRUCTURE

On your turn you **must** play at least one tile. You may play on:

- ♦ **Your own personal train** (always, if open or marked)
- ♦ **The Mexican Train** (always open to everyone)
- ♦ **Another player's train** only if it has a **train marker** on it (it is open)

If you cannot play on any available train:

- 1 Draw one tile from the boneyard.
- 2 If it can be played, play it.
- 3 If not, place your **train marker** on your personal train (marking it open for others).

Removing your marker: when you successfully play on your own marked train, remove the marker. Your train becomes private again.

DOUBLES

Playing a double on any train **immediately requires** the player who placed it to play another tile on that same double before their turn ends. If they cannot (no matching tile in hand, nothing drawable that matches), they draw once; if still unable, place a marker and the double remains open — **all players must satisfy the open double** before playing anywhere else on their turn.

END OF ROUND

A round ends when a player plays their last tile (**goes out**) or no player can play (blocked). Each player counts the pip total of their remaining tiles. Record scores. The player who went out scores 0.

MATCH

13 rounds (double-12 through double-0). After all rounds, the player with the **lowest cumulative pip total** wins.

ATTRIBUTION

Mexican Train. Origin disputed; popularised in the United States in the 1990s. Rules in the public domain. Source: Pagat.com (*Mexican Train*); Wikipedia (*Mexican Train*).